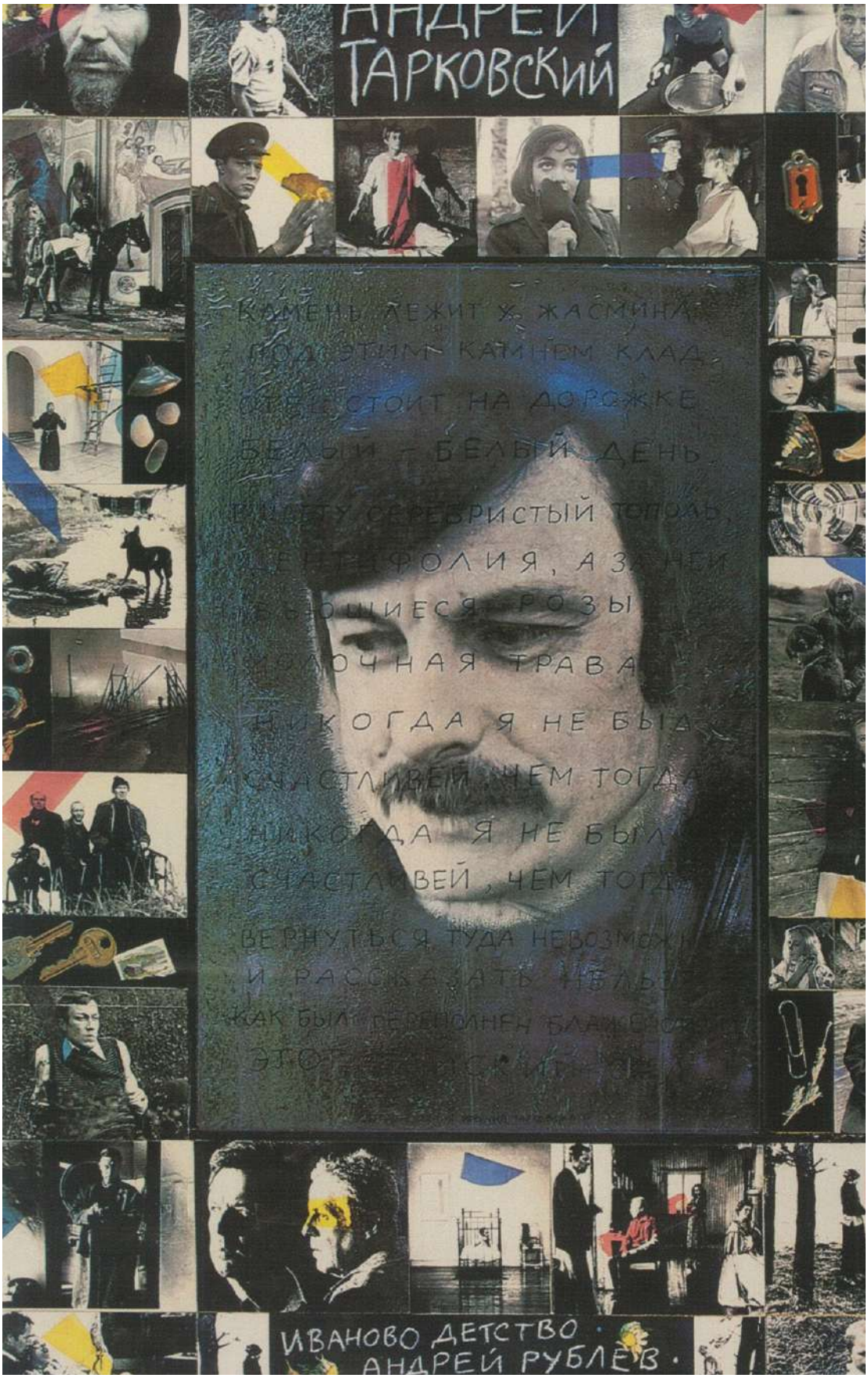
ANDREI TARKOVSKY AND NELLI FOMINA



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Written by
ALEKSANDRA EREMASHVILI

Under the direction of
AURORA FIORENTINI

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Andrey Tarkovsky and Nelli Fomina
during the shoot of the film ***Solaris,*** 1970 - 1972
Photograph by Vladimir Murashko

Biography of *A*ndrey *T*arkovsky

Art expresses all the best that is in a human being - Hope, Faith, Compassion, Beauty, Prayer. In other words, everything he dreams about and believes in…

- Andrei Tarkovsky

Andrei Tarkovsky (1932 - 1986) was born on 4th of April 1932 in the village of Zavrazhye (today a rural settlement of Ivanovo Oblast), into the family of Arseny Tarkovsky and Maria Vishnyakova. Zavrazhye - a fascinating panorama of Russian territory. Picturesque differences of landscape lines, forests, endless distances, the great Wolga river - here a child prodigy made his first inhale and was baptized. Two years after his birth his younger and only sister Marina was born whereupon the family moved to Moscow. Since Arseny Tarkovsky's departure from the family in 1935, children were compelled to grow without father's warmth. Regarding this, Andrei Tarkovsky spoke out that in his childhood years he saw his father extremely rarely and was going trough the lack of father's presence however he would never exchange mother's house for father's one. [The incarnation of this childhood memory we can see in "The Mirror" when Ignat's parents offer him to move from his mother's home to father's one which, subsequently, he indifferently declines.] Nevertheless, Andrei also claims that his father Arseny Tarkovsky - the famous and influencial russian poet - and his poetry played an important role in film director's creative development. Even

though the children were growing in severe military conditions, the mother Maria found a way to give her children the best possible education. Andrei attended music and art schools and successfully graduated Moscow State School No. 554. In 1951 young Andrei Tarkovsky entered the Moscow Institute of Oriental Studies as a student in the Arabic division of the Middle Eastern department but in 1954 resigned and entered the directing department of The Gerasimov Institute of Cinematography as known as VGIK. During his studies in VGIK Tarkovsky directed several short films and wrote a couple of screenplays. But his actual career of a film director began in 1962 with the shooting of his first independent film “Ivan’s Childhood”.

Andrey Tarkovsky as a child

Shooting the film. 1973 - 1974
Photograph by Vladimir Murashko

For his short but intense life, Andrey Tarkovsky shot only 7 internationally recognised films. As we can see from the above, two things that come from his childhood had a strong influence on Tarkovsky’s creative thinking and amazed him - memory and nature, both of which he has masterfully connected in his filmmaking.

> ***Memory is something we receive from nature as a dept for “past lives”. Memory is emotional and specific, dependent on the traits of each particular personality. Memory is a part of a character.***

- Andrey Tarkovsky

> ***My tender and melancholy feeling of love for nature amazes me. The thing that I consider most important for my filmmaking is the image of nature that is seared into the memory - water, trees, fields, rain, leaves, fences under sun, vegetable gardens and roofs among the trees made scorching hot by the summer sun.***
>
> *- Andrei Tarkovsky*

For instance, we can clearly see it in “Stalker” where Tarkovsky honed his inimitable visual style - long landscape scenes, slowly eddying streams of water and still lifes composed of objects that arouse complex chains of associations.

However Tarkovsky was always saying that it is easier for him to work in the cinema than in the theater, he directed two theatrical productions - “Hamlet” in Moscow Lenkom Theater in 1977 and “Boris Godunov” in London Covent Garden Theater in 1983. Both performances met a huge success. His preference to work in the cinema field rather than in the theater field Tarkovsky explained by pointing out that in the cinema there is no need to take into account the time or the rhythm of the viewer - a film has its own rhythm. If it were necessary to move a film to the stage, it would ruin its temporary atmosphere which is very important.

Because Andrei Tarkovsky was always in conflict with the soviet cinema system due to its constant restrictions on Tarkovsky’s ideas and production, in 1980 the film director traveled to Italy where he, in consequence, found an enormous inspiration, bought a family house and started working on “Nostalgia” together with Italian screenwriter Tonino Guerra. At some point, the film can be considered an autobiographical one because it is based on film director’s inner feelings during the immigration period. The impossibility to share vivid impressions of Italy with his loved ones was increasing Andrei Tarkovsky’s heartache and was making his stay in Italy a torment. At the same time, a necessity to find a kindred spirit that could understand and share his experiences awoke in him. Because

of this reason, the film is called “Nostalgia”. Due to Tarkovsky’s struggle to share his spirituality with another nation, due to his feeling of soul limitation, that the soul can not be broadened, as much as he wished it to be so.

Andrei Tarkovsky and Tonino Guerra working on the film’s screenplay

In the book “Tarkovsky. Lord!... I can feel Your hand on my nape” of Nikolai Burljaev - Andrei Tarkovsky’s friend and colleague - Nikolai tells that he often saw Tarkovsky cheerful or funny but he never saw him happy. After making decent research on Andrei Tarkovsky’s life and work and after formulating my personal thoughts regarding it, I would assume that all his life circumstances were such that brought him pain. But this pain was necessary for his soul so that the flame of creativity does not leave it. The pain was the source of his art, as I see it.

Aesthetical language of the film director

The films of Andrei Tarkovsky have made a special contribution to world cinema. Tarkovsky created unique films that organically fit into the context of world culture.

> ***Culture is a part of the people's souls. The art, as well as culture, need to be felt rather than merely understood***

- Andrei Tarkovsky

According to Andrei Tarkovsky, a true masterpiece of art must primarily affect the viewer's soul rather than be immediately understood because when the viewer solves the riddle of the artwork, it is depleted. And when he or she does not solve it, the artwork becomes endless.

The film director was talented in everything - in painting and music, photography and poetry - those are inseparable components of his work through which he was able to organize visual space all by himself. As proof, in the last years of his life and creative career Andrei Tarkovsky combined a love for painting and drawing with a passion for photography. This also helped him with concrete professional tasks such as the selection of shooting

locations in Italy where he eventually shot “Nostalgia” and in Sweden where “The Sacrifice” was shot. With astonishing regularity, Tarkovsky shows us world art masterpieces in his films and in each case they serve to express the idea of the film or the film as a whole or one of its individual scenes. For instance, the painting “Legend of Saint Ursula” by Carpaccio defined one of the main ideas of “Solaris”, about the rejection of disunity and the need for understanding among people. As well as, in “Andrei Rublev” we can see the icons of Rublev himself or the image of Ginevra de Benci painted by Leonardo da Vinci is present in Solaris in the trimming of Hari’s dress.

Ginevra de’ Benci 1474 - 1478
Leonardo da Vinci

Shooting «Solaris»
1970 - 1972

Andrei Tarkovsky drew and painted his entire life which meant self-expression. From children’s drawings to storyboards for short films.

Andrei Tarkovsky’s sketches

In Andrei Tarkovsky's opinion, culture and true art can not exist without religion.

> ***Cinema should not shoot the world, but faith in this world, which is our only connection with it.***

- Andrei Tarkovsky

Because of this, all films of Tarkovsky without exception push a viewer to think about the meaning of existence, about eternity, and the topic of religion plays a crucial role in Tarkovsky's creativity.

Another theme that the director has precisely reflected in his works is the anxiety and the problem of that time. Tarkovsky was interested in the problem of the gap between two worlds: of our earthy world and of the divine "paradise" world and he told that the cinema is like the matrix of time - is able to fix time.

> ***Just as a sculptor takes a block of marble and, feeling the inner features of his future thing, removes everything superfluous, a cinematographer cuts off and discards everything unnecessary from a block of time covering a huge and undifferentiated set of vital factors***

- Andrei Tarkovsky

To illustrate, in "Andrei Rublev" we observe how the medieval artist searches not only for the self-realization, but also we see his desire to recreate the severed connection between the earthly and transcendental worlds. As far as I can see, the director also incarnates his anxiety of that time by sculpting his characters. All protagonists in Andrei Tarkovsky's films are in a state of extreme overstrain and deep mental imbalance, where the protagonist must either break down or establish himself in faith in his ideals and principles.

In his works, Andrei Tarkovsky did not orate but looked closely and listened to the world, to its elements - and to the elements of the cinema as a special way of cognition and expression. He generally thought that a painter should not fuss. The more turbulent the temperament of a painter, the less expressive their art. For Tarkovsky the cinema was a “moral occupation, not a professional one”, and, for that reason, his films acquire more adherents with each passing year.

Shooting the film. 1985. Gotland

Biography of Nelli Fomina

Nelli Fomina and Andrei Tarkovsky on the set of «Stalker».

Nelli Fomina (1937 - 2020) - costume designer, Honoured Worker of the USSR, member of the Union of Cinematographers - was born on the 9th of October 1937 in Krasnodar Territory. Since her childhood, Nelli loved to draw. After graduating from high school in Perm, Nelli worked at the aircraft factory where she attended drawing classes. After that, young Nelli Fomina risked moving to Moscow in order to enter The Textile Institute. In those days, for an ordinary provincial schoolgirl, such a step could be considered a desperate and risky one but after one failed attempt Nelli was after all successfully enrolled in the Faculty of Applied Art at the Textile Institute. An unexpected occasion brought Nelli Fomina to the cinema industry. When she was working on her graduate work, her friend unexpectedly asked Nelli to substitute for her at the Mosfilm studio because she was offered a job on television. Thereby, Nelli Fomina started her career as an assistant costume designer in the amazing world of cinema, later working on the Mosfilm from 1965 to 1999 and creating costumes for 40 films and 5 theatrical performances. Besides, Nelli collaborated with Maya Plisetskaya - the famous ballet dancer of Bolshoi Theatre - for whom she designed several costumes. Since 1998 she was also giving lectures on “The History of Costume” and “The Role and Significance of Costume in Film» at the

Advanced Courses for Script-writers and Directors in Moscow. In 2004 Nelli Fomina was included in the “General Dictionary of Artists” published in Germany for her invaluable contribution to the development of art, where it is written: “Her works are distinguished by its elegance and precision and her ability to express convincingly the characters of the actors she dresses.” Drawings and sketches by Nelli Fomina are exhibited in the most famous and important Russian museums and galleries, among which are: the Central State Museum of Cinema, the Russian State Library, the Mosfilm Museum, and the State Tretyakov Gallery.

Pause during a rain shower. Sergei Naugolnykh and Nelli Fomina

The dialog of art between Tarkovsky and Fomina

Costumes are a very important part of the general artistic presentation of a film. A high degree of sensitivity is very important. I would say that an actor's shirt has to be made out of the same material as his face. You will understand what I mean when I use a metaphor like that. I am talking about attitude. <...> Everything needs to be a result of extremely careful thought and selection. The highest standards need to be applied even when it comes to details as small as buttons. In Vermeer's paintings, a torn sleeve is an item of imperishable value, a whole inspired world of it is own. A newly created costume for an actor is always a disaster. A costume, just like anything else in a film, must have a life of its own, linked with a specific person, a specific actor, That can always be seen, because a costume is like any other aspect of reality - it changes over time, just like everything else.

- Andrei Tarkovsky

The meeting of Andrei and Nelli was the same coincidence as Nelli's arrival in the film industry. Once in 1969, Fomina's colleague and friend Larisa - the future wife of Andrei Tarkovsky - invited her to their house where Nelli and Andrey met each other. In the future, two professionals will be working together on the production of Tarkovsky's three most remarkable films: "Solaris" (1972), "The Mirror" (1974), and "Stalker" (1979). The costume designer tells that from their first meeting Andrei left an impression of an

erudite and unusual person who deeply understands music and painting. Their relationships developed easily and naturally and Nelli was always amazed by his ability to conduct a dialog. Those creative decisions that we can see today in “Solaris”, “The Mirror”, and “Stalker” the costume designer found in a dialog with Tarkovsky. In particular, he paid attention to the details of a costume because they can tell a lot about the character and their state.

It is necessary not only to dress the character. The most important aspect is that the costume must match the character's image.

- Nelli Fomina

A costume designer was making sketches for films in a different manner depending on the plot since, in the sketch, it is of paramount importance to take into account the wishes of the director and embody them in clothes. Even for a short episode a costume and makeup were discussed in detail with the director. In turn, Andrei Tarkovsky was very attentive to the texture of a costume but in those times the choice of fabrics was limited. Considering this fact, Fomina was forced to invent some textures by herself. According to Tarkovsky, the sculpting of a character must be down-to-earth, as well as, the costumes must be natural and genuine. He often told that the colors of the costumes should not attract the spectator’s attention, and colors should not be noticeable. In addition, he held a strict opinion that the costumes must not be brand-new but shabby. Since during the film processes, Andrei Tarkovsky could make adjustments to the costumes and due to complicated scripts, Nelli Fomina was asked to be constantly present on a set.

Stay here. Sew, knit, read but do not leave the pavilion. I am stressed when you are not here.

- Andrei Tarkovsky to Nelli Fomina

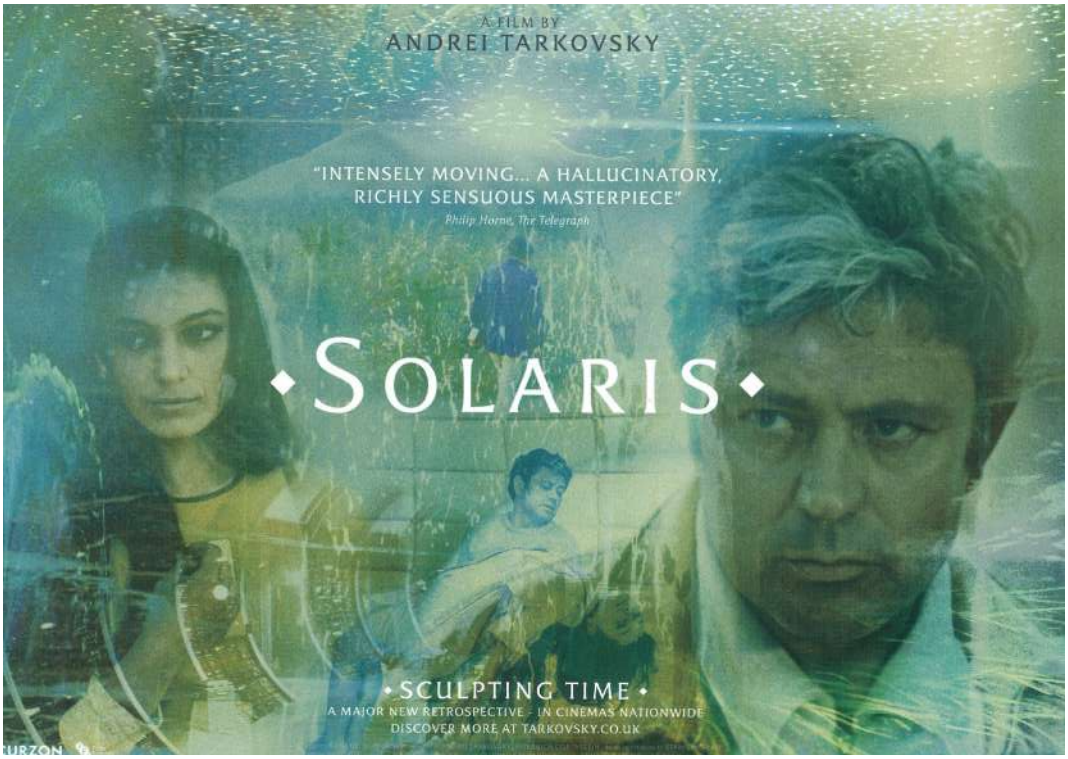
Ideas on costumes the film director agreed on immediately but some of them required improvement. Eventually, Andrey Tarkovsky always wanted to see a finished costume to make his final decision.

Leave me be. Make sure you come up with something I like.

- Andrei Tarkovsky to Nelli Fomina

Fomina was always allowed to argue with Tarkovsky and make her proposals, he was always up to any idea. That is why working with him was always easy for Nelli despite the very complicated plots. At the same time, the costume designer remembers that working with Andrei was as difficult as much as interesting. Despite extraordinary tasks put by the film director to the costume designer, the main point was that both were keen on the idea of the film and were in a constant creative dialogue, and, as Fomina says, in the costume search dialogue they always converged.

Solaris 1972



Solaris is the science fiction transformed into a philosophical work of great moral force where Andrei Tarkovsky examined such timeless questions as duty, guilt, and love via the Intelligent Ocean of Solaris with its ability to materialize people's memories.

Initially, on the shooting of Solaris started working with another costume designer but Tarkovsky broke off collaboration with him before the start of filming because Andrei did not like the costumes which the initial costume designer has bought. So, when shortly after Nelli Fomina started working on this film, she was restricted in time and budget because a big budget was spent and the cost estimate for the new costumes was not increased.

Tarkovsky immediately issued an ultimatum that there should be no cosmic costumes in the film, despite the space theme of the film. Otherwise, in 30 years the film risks being misunderstood. Indeed, for instance, Kris' mesh shirt looks very inventive and modern not only for those times, but also for today so, in this way, even after so many years, the costumes for the film are not outdated.

Kris Kelvin (Donatas Basionis) after his arrival on the space-station)

As already mentioned before, the film director used to modify and adjust the screenwriting during the shooting and so the shooting of Solaris was not without surprises as well. Suddenly, Andrei Tarkovsky claimed that he had rewritten the text and that in one particular scene Kris must wear not a nightgown but a pajama. Fomina objected that despite the corrections in the text, the scene remained the same and that Kris must wear the initially prescribed costume. However, Tarkovsky asked her not to argue and, as a result of this confusion, it turned out that in the episode when Kris is in the room, he wears a nightgown but when he shortly after goes out into the corridor he already wears a pajama. Consequently, the only thing that Andrei said was: “Never mind, we can not shoot the scene again. It will have to stay like that, it is science fiction, and no one will notice…”

Because Tarkovsky always insisted that everything needs to look real in the film, the protagonist Kris appears in “Solaris” in a casual costume. The grey jumper matches the cream trousers and the dark-blue leather jacket. Since there was no variety of fabrics at that time, the costume designer was compelled to invent a new texture. To create light-beige trousers Nelli

Fomina used some special fine suede of the kind camera-men would use to clean their lenses. She diluted some pale emulsion paint, dipped some muslin into the gluey mixture, and stuck the muslin to the back of the suede. When the actor put them on for the first time, the trousers clung to his legs and, in this way, never lost their shape. Tarkovsky was astonished when he found out how Nelli had created those trousers.

When approving another costume - the one for Kris' father - the film director was unsatisfied that the sleeveless jacket was new. "Remove trimming and age it!" - exclaimed Tarkovsky. And Nelli together with him threw it on earth and started stomping it and even purposely burned it with a cigarette. The actor who played Kris' Father in "Solaris" - Nikolai Grinko, emphasized: "My costume was not less important for Andrei than my dialog".

In the scene with Negbour's Daughter and Berton's Grandson were used such collars in costumes that according to them it was possible to determine in which year the film was shot. To prevent the material from looking smooth and uninteresting, Nelli Fomina drew out some horizontal and vertical threads all over it and that was how the chequered effect was achieved.

Nikolai Grinko and Andrei Tarkovsky

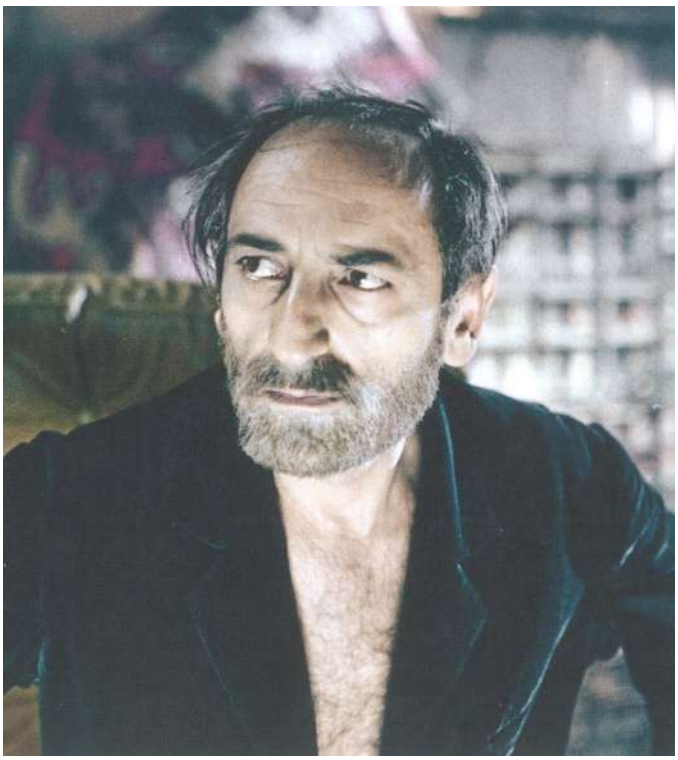
Berton's son, the neighbour's daughter and Kris's father's dog

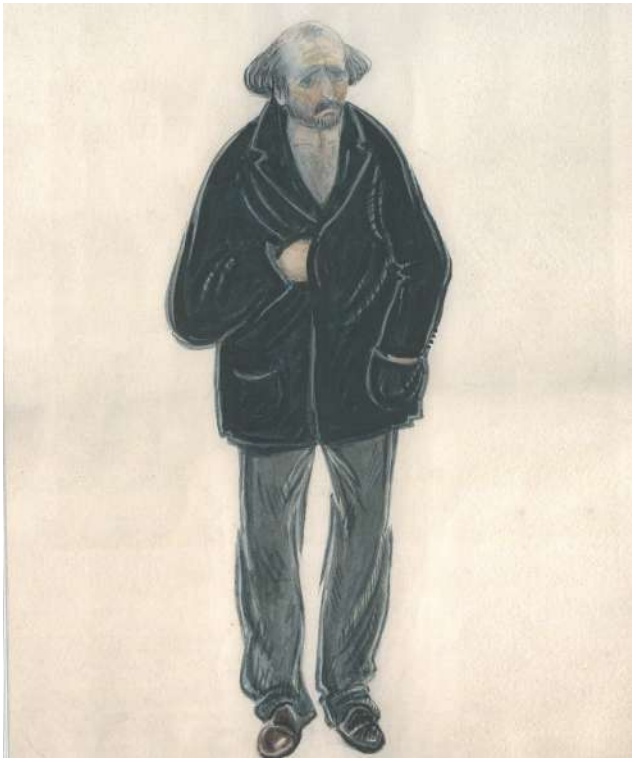
Another distinctive feature of Andrei Tarkovsky was that he was often asked to add initials to his character's costumes. We can see the letters "A.T", which means Andrei Tarkovsky, in "Solaris" on the breast pocket of Kris' jacket as well as in "Stalker" on the motorcycle helmets at the beginning of the film. Also, he asked to put Kris's initials on pajamas - K.K. which means Kris Kelvin. On overalls worn by other characters, the names "Kris" and "Hari" have been added. Andrei Tarkovsky attached great importance to such details.

For the costume of Gibarian who committed suicide in the space station, the film director asked Nelli to think about what details in the costume would emphasize the astronaut's depressed state. Fomina proposed to put a black velvet robe right on the actor's naked body. Velvet absorbs the light and the details are invisible on it. In this way, the costume does not disturb the spectator from the character's concentrated face. To add, considering Gibarian tragical conditions, he would certainly not have been thinking

about his appearance and could unconsciously have put on a robe without a shirt underneath it. Such a decision emphasized Gibarian's detachment.

Hari and Kris wearing suits with initials





Gibarian wearing a black velvet jacket

It is noticeable that the film director often correlates the images of wives with the images of mothers. We can see it in “The Mirror” where the appearance of the protagonist’s wife is identical to his mother’s. As well as in “Solaris” where Tarkovsky asked to create similar costumes for Kris’s lover and his mother. For these costumes, Nelli chose a yarn of an untwisted kind that has a fluffy texture and gives a sensation of coziness and home warmth.

Rehearsal for the scene «Kris’ dream»

In the scene when Kris tries to get rid of Hari and sends her off from the space station on a rocket, Kris’ costume needed to be naturally burnt. Nelli Fomina used a candle to burn the sleeve and back of his overalls and Andrei supervised the process calling out the instructions in happy excitement: “Burn away, burn it more!”. So the costume designer decided to apply such kind of technique with ash in order not to leave stains and easily brush it off without leaving any traces.

However, Nelli Fomina remembers that especially hard for her was the key scene in the film when Hari drinks liquid oxygen. Then Tarkovsky issued instructions: “The shirt must be frozen but gradually when Hari comes to life it melts.” Then Nelli Fomina came up with a fantastic but technically complicated idea. She soaked a small piece of cloth in a salt solution, squeezed it, dried it, sprayed the piece of cloth with water, and then watches as it began to “melt”. Andrei was thrilled with her solution but then asked

to replace salt with sugar to avoid the actress's skin irritation. Andrei Tarkovsky had even taken that into consideration.

Kris Kelvin after an attempt to get free of Hari launching her off the space-station in a rocket

Hari forces her way through a metal door

The Mirror 1974

"The Mirror", where Andrei Tarkovsky raised such immortal topics as devotion, duty and love, is an autobiographic film for him. Nevertheless, the director decided to incarnate only two costumes from his personal archive - an exact copy of the ornament on his mother's dress and his father's military uniform. Other costumes must generally create a military atmosphere. The entire color palette was carefully selected and coordinated with the director and cameraman of the film. The whole color scheme of the costumes was soft and muted.

In accordance with Andrei's, overall concept of the film, the role of Alexei's wife and mother were played by the same actress. In the scenes where the actress Margarita Terekhova played the wife of the hero, Tarkovsky asked her to wear her own clothes: this underlined the transition from one era to another. As time changes, so does the costume and it is through details of costume that the appearance of the two different leading women is

conveyed to the audience. The role of the Mother in old age was performed by Andrei Tarkovsky's mother - Maria Vishnyakova. Andrei suggested that Maria acts in her usual clothes so that she would be comfortable. On the set, Tarkovsky treated his mother with great attention and care.

For Liza's role, Nelli Fomina acquired an old cambric blouse with lotus flowers. Knowing the difficult character of the actress who played Lisa, Nelli suggested that she choose a costume on her own by offering her several blouses, including the one she had acquired. Nelli also asked Andrei to be present at the fitting and support her. Finally, actress Alla Demidova chose exactly the blouse that Fomina managed to acquire. A knitted cardigan was put around her shoulders so as to emphasize how bleak the atmosphere at the printing house was.

Anna Demidova (Liza) wearing an old-fashioned embroidered blouse

Sketch of Nelli Fomina's children clothes

For the scene where Alexei and Marina were in their early childhood, the pale dress with lacing in the front that Marina wore had been provided by one of Fomina's childhood photos.

For the scene "At the shooting gallery" Nelli Fomina collected old and shabby sets of clothes for the children but Tarkovsky insisted that even the old clothes were even more torn and stained. Those sets of clothes needed to be monochrome, so that attention should not be drawn to individual details. All attention was focused on the inner condition of those children.

That scene was taken when the temperature was -20 degrees.

The same actor played both Alexei as a child and Ignat - Ignat Daniltsev. It was important that Alexei's costume translated the desperate position of the family during the terrible war years: he wore a shabby cardigan done up on the woman's side, a crumpled sleeveless jacket made of plush - an obvious hand-me-down - and short grey trousers made of heavy-duty cotton, typical of those times. The sleeveless jacket looked old and worn after the costume designer had dyed and pressed it.

The costume of the Doctor's Wife needed to be well-thought since her clothes were supposed to show the prosperity of her family - the opposite of the family in which Alexei was growing up. Nelli Fomina's idea was that the color of the Doctor's Wife's satin crepe housecoat is muted but deep. It did not attract too much of the audience's attention but high-quality and expensive material would still show that its owner was prosperous. Not every woman in those days could allow herself the luxury of crepe-backed satin that was fashionable but expensive. The image of this character fully revealed itself when the Doctor's Wife showed her child who was sleeping in a dazzling white night dress trimmed with lace. To highlight the contrast, in the same scene Alexei's mother appeared in a very simple garment of a restrained color range. Her dress was khaki-colored, her knitted jacket was grey and on her feet, she had just shoes with narrow straps put on barefoot.

Stalker 1979

Stalker is a film about man's predestination, the search for a place between faith and reason, and the fact that no technical achievements or political parties will be able to solve today's problems until man learns to overcome himself.

Initially, Andrei Tarkovsky wanted Stalker wears the same jacket as Kris in Solaris but a brown one, not a black one. But Nelli Fomina objected to this idea substantiating that the spectators could think that the film crew took off Kris' jacket, repainted it, and put it on the Stalker. Then they agreed that Nelli would make her own version and they would compare two of their ideas. In a stock, Fomina found one very old long shabby jacket which even did not have to be aged. Nelli brought both jackets to the fitting and, at last, the director recognized her version as more convincing. This chosen jacket was a unique copy, so, on the set, the film crew tried to take care of it and used some other jacket for rehearsals. However, Tarkovsky lacked

something to complete the image. Since the director wanted to show the influence of the Zone in the image of the Stalker, he was looking for ways to embody it in a costume. Nelli Fomina suggested putting a scarf around a neck but later Tarkovsky came up with his own idea on how to incarnate the influence of the Zone: he made up his mind on a dirty bandage around Stalker's neck that he never takes off to cover an unhealed wound. That was how the image was finally approved.

Make sure that you yourself put a bandage on the actor and not someone else.

- Andrei Tarkovsky to Nelli Fomina

Stalker

The Writer's costume was supposed to reflect the influence of the Zone as well. According to the script, at some point, his coat was going to get wet on his back. Nelli Fomina worried about this episode because, in her opinion, the wetting of a broadcloth coat will be such unnoticeable that the screen will unable to transmit it and she recommended installing additional lightning for this scene in order to make the wetting visible. But Andrei Tarkovsky still wanted to check that out himself. In this regard, Fomina sew long rubber tubes with holes onto the inside of the Writer's coat and water was then pumped into them. That was followed by a long wait. A puddle had already formed on the ground at the Writer's feet but there was no sign of moisture on the coat itself. After seeing how long it took for the wet patch to become visible, Andrei dropped this idea. When wet and dirty scenes were being filmed, the actor was given backup versions of the coat.

The Writer

For the costume designer, it is important not only to create an image of a character through the clothes but also to think through how these clothes will be changing shot by shot depending on external conditions in order to protect an actor or an actress from unpredicted circumstances. As proof, for the episode when The Stalker's Wife had a panic attack, Nelli chose a knitted nightgown so that the actress is not distracted by the inconvenience

of the costume.

The Stalker's Wife

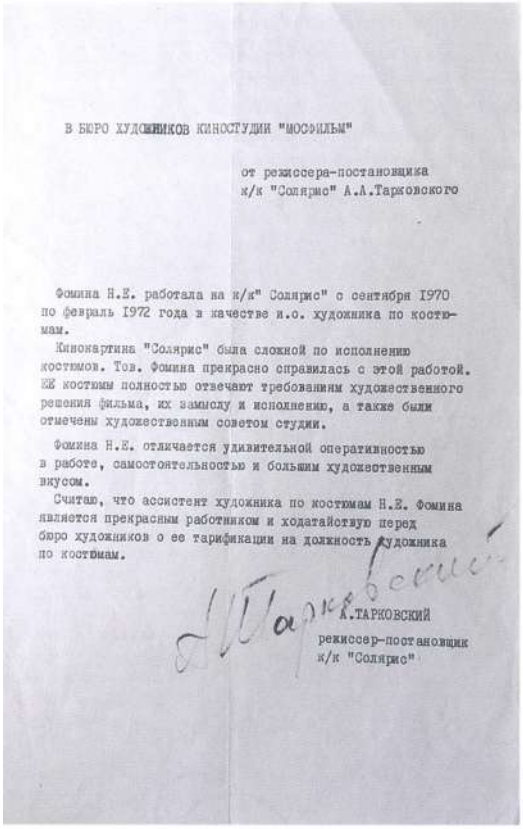
There was also an unpredicted circumstance that happened on the set of "Stalker". The girl who played the Stalker's daughter had a too-short haircut. Someone even proposed to substitute the actress but Tarkovsky insisted exactly on the first actress. The hairstylist was fitting the wigs for a very long time but then Nelli suggested putting silk antique headscarf and Tarkovsky immediately approved this solution saying that such a decision will give the image completeness.

The Stalker's Daughter with The Stalker's Wife

Conclusion

The collaboration of Andrei Tarkovsky and Nelli Fomina was an introduction to her professional career and her first experience in a role of a costume designer. Before she only assisted. Fomina admired how deeply Tarkovsky understood global art and she considered him as her unwritten teacher of self-education - of music, literature, and, obviously, cinema.

According to the costume designer's words, a collaboration with the great master significantly influenced her creative development. Andrei Tarkovsky was spreading his enthusiasm to everyone on set, he was joining the preparation of objects, and was showing how to improve a shot. He was always very attentive to Nelli Fomina's suggestions but without ceasing to monitor by himself not only the condition of the costume but also the condition of the makeup and hairstyle of the actor. Nelli was always impressed with his desire to do everything independently, on his own, and called him her tacit fine art, music, literature, and, of course, cinema teacher. And he, in turn, highly appreciated Nelli Fomina's work and considered her an indispensable colleague on the set.



В БЮРО ХУДОЖНИКОВ КИНОСТУДИИ "МОСФИЛЬМ"

от режиссера-постановщика
к/к "Солярис" А.А.Тарковского

Фомина Н.Е. работала на к/к" Солярис" с сентября 1970 по февраль 1972 года в качестве и.о. художника по костюмам.

Кинокартина "Солярис" была сложной по исполнению костюмов. Тов. Фомина прекрасно справилась с этой работой. ЕЕ костюмы полностью отвечают требованиям художественного решения фильма, их замыслу и исполнению, а также были отмечены художественным советом студии.

Фомина Н.Е. отличается удивительной оперативностью в работе, самостоятельностью и большим художественным вкусом.

Считаю, что ассистент художника по костюмам Н.Е. Фомина является прекрасным работником и ходатайствую перед бюро художников о ее тарификации на должность художника по костюмам.

А.ТАРКОВСКИЙ
режиссер-постановщик
к/к "Солярис"

TO THE OFFICE OF THE ARTISTIC DEPARTMENT OF MOSFILM STUDIOS

From A.A.Tarkovsky, Director of the film *Solaris*.

Regarding N.E.Fomina, who worked on the film *Solaris* from September 1970 to February 1972 as acting costume designer.

The film *Solaris* was a complex one as regards the creation of the costumes. Comrade Fomina coped splendidly with the demands of this task. Her costumes correspond completely to the artistic requirements of the film, both as regards the ideas behind the costumes and their creation. This was duly noted by the artistic board at the Mosfilm studios.

N.E.Fomina carried out her work with astonishing speed and efficiency. Her independent approach and artistic sensitivity were much appreciated.

I consider that Assistant Costume Designer N.E.Fomina is a first-class designer and request that the office of the artistic department should raise her current employment status to that of costume designer.

Signed: A. Tarkovsky
Director of the film *Solaris*

In each of Tarkovsky's pretty distinctive pictures - historicals, narratives, autobiographicals, science fiction works - the director speaks to the viewer about moral choices, the joy of love and the tragedy of loss, as well as, about the power of art and the meaning of human life. The director managed to fix something that will always remain inaccessible to the human eye: time, faith, and atmosphere. In this way, Andrei Tarkovsky's cinema is a key that opens not only the mind but also people's hearts and souls.

Andrei Tarkovsky shooting the film «The Sacrifice». 1985. Gotland

On the set of the film «Stalker»

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